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Understanding the role of social media influencers' personal and content characteristics in affecting consumers' intentions to purchase

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ABSTRACT

This study attempts to determine factors influencing consumers' purchase intentions for products endorsed by social media influencers (SMIs) using the theory of planned behaviour as the base theory. Specifically, it aims to examine how SMIs' personal and content characteristics impact consumers' attitudes towards purchasing these endorsed products. A total of 217 data were collected from social media users by means of a survey method. Partial least square structural equation modelling is employed to verify the proposed hypotheses. The study shows that attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control have a significant positive influence on purchase intentions. Furthermore, trustworthiness, creativity, and design quality have a significant influence on attitudes. However, attractiveness, expertise, and information quality have no significant influence on attitudes. This is one of the very few studies to examine consumers' purchase intentions from two different perspectives based on SMIs' personal and content characteristics integrating the theory of planned behaviour.

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Personal characteristics;
Content characteristics;
theory of planned behaviour;
PLS-SEM

1. Introduction

One of the most significant challenges brands encounter is competing with other brands while effectively conveying their brand message to both current and potential customers (Shamim, Azam, and Islam 2024; Sohaib and Han 2023). The rise of social media has revolutionised how consumers communicate with each other and how brands execute their marketing strategies (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. 2022a; Cheung, Leung, Yang, et al. 2022b; Koay et al. 2020). This shift in communication channels has made marketing efforts both simpler and more complex; consumers now have unprecedented access to information (Hosta and Zabkar 2021). To navigate this digital landscape, many marketers have increasingly turned to social media influencer marketing, a strategy that has gained widespread acceptance and use (Cheah, Koay, and Lim 2024; D. Y. Kim and Kim 2021; Koay and Lim, 2024). Social media influencers (SMIs) are motivated to endorse a company's products to their followers on social media platforms, aiming to enhance

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the company's overall performance (Aw and Chuah 2021; Ooi et al. 2023). SMIs can vary widely, including lesser-known actors and models, fitness enthusiasts, affluent individuals with a passion for luxury brands, as well as university and school students (Tanwar, Chaudhry, and Srivastava 2024). By leveraging their unique appeal and reach, SMIs help businesses connect with diverse audience segments and boost their market presence (Polat et al. 2024; Ren et al. 2023).

SMIs are individuals who have amassed a significant following on social media platforms and possess the ability to sway their audience's attitudes and behaviours (Koay et al., 2024; Vrontis et al. 2021). Their substantial impact on consumer behaviour, including influencing purchasing decisions and shaping societal norms, has made them a focal point of academic research (IZEA Insights 2022). Notably, 56% of consumers have reported making purchases based on SMIs' recommendations (IZEA Insights 2022). Consequently, spending on influencer marketing surged by 87.5% from 2019 to 2020, increasing from \$8 billion to \$15 billion (Business Insider 2021), and the industry was valued at \$16.4 billion in 2022 (IZEA Insights 2022). In addition, it was reported that SMIs are 6.9 times more effective than traditional marketing strategies in attracting and convincing digital consumers (Ye et al. 2021). As a result, over 65% of global brands plan to invest in influencer marketing, with anticipated spending expected to reach \$373 million by 2027 (Tanwar, Chaudhry, and Srivastava 2024). This significant shift underscores the growing importance of SMIs in modern marketing strategies as brands recognise their powerful impact on consumer behaviour and engagement.

Factors influencing consumers' purchase intentions endorsed by SMIs have been examined by a multitude number of studies. For instance, most of the existing studies examined the influence of SMIs' source credibility (Jang et al. 2021; Weismueller et al. 2020) and the influence of content characteristics endorsed by SMIs (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. 2022a; M. T. Lee and Theokary 2021). However, very limited studies combined the two perspectives to understand why consumers decide to purchase products endorsed by SMIs. As such, this study attempts to employ the theory of planned behaviour (TPB) (Ajzen 1991, 2011) as the base theory and then combine factors based on SMIs' personal and content characteristics to predict attitudes towards products endorsed by SMIs. Examining the impact of SMIs' personal and content characteristics on attitudes is crucial for two main reasons. Firstly, the TPB suggests that a person's intentions and actions can be efficiently predicted by three elements including attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control (Ajzen 1991). Ajzen (1991) also stated that TPB can be modified if additional factors improve its predictive power. Therefore, the basic TPB may not fully explain why consumers buy products endorsed by SMIs, potentially limiting marketers' ability to develop effective strategies. To address this, the study expands the original TPB framework by incorporating SMIs' personal and content characteristics to better predict attitudes. Secondly, previous research has indicated that SMIs' personal traits and content characteristics play a key role in influencing consumers' purchasing decisions (e.g., Dhun, Dangi, and 2023; Koay et al. 2022; Ooi et al. 2023).

The remainder of this paper is organised as follows. The next section reviews the literature, focusing on the TPB as the foundational theory for this study. It also examines the impact of personal and content characteristics on consumer attitudes, which informs the development of the study's hypotheses. Following this, the methodology and steps of the study are outlined, along with the results from the analysis of PLS-SEM. Finally, the

paper concludes by discussing its theoretical contributions, managerial implications, limitations, and suggestions for future research.

2. Literature review

2.1. *Theory of planned behaviour*

The TPB, introduced by Ajzen in the late 1980s, provides a valuable framework for understanding the factors that influence human behaviour (Ajzen 1991). According to TPB, behaviour is determined by three main components: attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control. These elements collectively shape an individual's intentions, which in turn lead to actual behaviour. Attitudes refer to an individual's positive or negative evaluations of performing a specific behaviour (Ajzen 1991). In the realm of social media influencer marketing, for instance, positive attitudes are formed when individuals perceive favourable outcomes from purchasing products endorsed by SMIs. These positive evaluations then contribute to the intention to make such purchases and ultimately to the purchasing behaviour itself. Subjective norms involve the perceived social pressure from others to perform or not perform a particular behaviour (Ajzen 1991). This component assesses the influence of societal and peer expectations on an individual's intention and behaviour. For example, if people believe that their peers or society expects them to use certain products endorsed by SMIs, they are more likely to form the intention to purchase these products. Perceived behavioural control pertains to an individual's perception of their ability to perform a given behaviour, considering any potential obstacles (Ajzen 1991). It reflects how easy or difficult they believe it is to carry out the behaviour.

2.2. *Source credibility model (personal characteristics)*

Source credibility encompasses all positive attributes that influence a recipient's acceptance of a message and the traits that impact an individual's perception (Ohanian 1990). According to Ohanian (1990), source credibility refers to 'the positive characteristics of a communicator that affect their receiver's acceptance of a message' (p. 41). The recipient's acceptance of a message is influenced by the perceived credibility of its source, indicating the level of belief and trust the recipient has in the sender (Wu and Wang 2011). Initially, Ohanian's (1990) source credibility model was applied to movie and music celebrities. However, recent research (Koay et al. 2022; Weismueller et al. 2020) has expanded this model to assess the impact of SMIs' credibility on consumer behaviour. In the context of social media, source reliability refers to the perceived trustworthiness, knowledge, and credibility of content creators (Zha et al. 2018). Ohanian's (1990) study identifies three main components of source credibility: attractiveness, expertise, and trustworthiness.

Attractiveness, on the other hand, pertains to the physical appeal of the individual, which plays a crucial role in forming first impressions. Messages delivered by attractive individuals significantly influence others' opinions and evaluations of products or places (Ohanian 1990). Thus, attractiveness can greatly enhance the impact of the message conveyed. Expertise refers to the source's adequate knowledge and skills in their domain

(Ohanian 1990). SMIs are seen as reliable if they demonstrate expertise in their field (Colliander and Marder 2018). Trustworthiness involves the perceived honesty, character, and credibility of the source. The perceived effectiveness of a message increases when the source is seen as both knowledgeable and trustworthy (Keel and Nataraajan 2012).

2.3. Content characteristics

In addition to SMIs' personal characteristics, the characteristics of their content significantly influence consumers' decisions to purchase endorsed products. Several studies have highlighted the critical role of curated content in capturing consumers' attention and influencing their purchase decisions (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. 2022a; M. T. Lee and Theokary 2021). The creation of sponsored content can substantially affect consumers' perceptions and their subsequent purchase intentions (Xie and Feng 2023). Therefore, this study focuses on exploring key content characteristics, namely information quality, creativity, and design quality.

2.4. Hypotheses development

2.4.1. Attitudes and purchase intentions

The TPB postulates that when an individual expresses more positive attitudes towards a particular behaviour, the more likely the individual possesses the intention to perform that particular behaviour (Ajzen 1991). The likelihood of consumers purchasing a product or service increases when they express positive attitudes towards that particular product or service (B. Han, Kim, and Lee 2018). Establishing consumers' attitudes in a favourable manner is crucial as it is postulated to significantly influence consumer purchase intention in both online and offline settings (Dogra and Kaushal 2023). SMIs are viewed as independent advocates who leverage social media platforms or tools to shape the attitudes of their followers and audiences (Lin et al. 2021). Attitudes are shaped by an overall evaluation of the benefits and drawbacks associated with a particular behaviour (Koay et al. 2022). A study by Chetoui, Benlafqih, and Lebdaoui (2020), based on fashion influencers, suggests that SMIs not only influence consumers' attitudes towards a brand but also encourage purchase intention. Moreover, positive attitudes towards SMIs' product recommendations are found to positively influence consumers' intentions to buy the recommended products (Cabeza-Ramírez et al. 2022). With these, the following hypothesis is formulated:

H1: Attitudes have a positive influence on purchase intentions.

2.4.2. Subjective norms

Subjective norms refer to an individual's perception of societal expectations and the behaviours of others around them. Essentially, it is the perceived social pressure to perform or not perform a specific behaviour (Ajzen 1991). An individual may perceive that people around them (family, friends, peers, colleagues, social constructs) either approve or disapprove of a certain behaviour, which influences their likelihood of engaging in that particular behaviour (Rhodes and Courneya 2003). A study on influencer-owned brands by Magrizos et al. (2021) revealed that subjective norms significantly

impact purchase intention. Additionally, research exploring SMLs' influence on students' dietary choices shows a significant relationship between subjective norms and behavioural intention (Ahmad and Bruno 2021). Similarly, in another study, subjective norms were found to positively affect consumers' purchase intention towards products recommended by SMLs (Cabeza-Ramírez et al. 2022; Tiwari et al. 2024). Therefore, it is hypothesised:

H2: Subjective norms have a positive influence on purchase intentions.

2.4.3. Perceived behavioural control

Perceived behavioural control refers to an individual's overall assessment of their ability to perform a certain behaviour in a given specific context (Ajzen 1991). It is an important element from the TPB in predicting an individual's behaviour. To effectively understand and predict one's behaviour, it is essential to 'assess both intention and actual behavioural control (i.e., relevant skills and abilities as well as barriers to and facilitators of behaviour performance)' (Fishbein and Ajzen 2009, 21). Despite having the intention to perform a specific behaviour, individuals may encounter constraints such as resources, time, price, and availability that impede their ability to do so (Terry and O'Leary 1995). The role of SMLs is to communicate product information to followers (Yuan and Lou 2020), which may make it easier for followers to make purchases. Building on this, the following hypothesis is formulated:

H3: Perceived behavioural control has a positive influence on purchase intentions.

2.4.4. Attractiveness

Physical attractiveness has been widely studied due to its significant role in changing attitudes (Berscheid and Walster 1974). Because of its significance, advertising media are more inclined to endorse models perceived as attractive with the objective of changing consumers' attitudes towards a brand (Ohanian 1990). Attractiveness refers to an SML being physically appealing or likable (Nafees et al. 2021). A study on celebrity advertising found that the perceived attractiveness of endorsed celebrities positively influences audience attitudes towards the advertisement (Bhatt, Jayswal, and Patel 2013). A study by Shoukat, Selem, and Shah (2023) found that the perceived attractiveness of SMLs has a positive impact on consumer purchase intentions, suggesting that the influence is based on psychological factors such as attitudes. Additionally, E. H. Kim (2022) reported that SMLs who are viewed as attractive are found to significantly positively influence attitudes towards products recommended by SMLs. Based on the findings of past studies, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H4: Attractiveness has a positive influence on attitudes.

2.4.5. Expertise

Expertise refers to the degree to which a source is considered knowledgeable and competent in making accurate statements (Ohanian 1990). Individuals are more inclined to be influenced by celebrities whom they perceive as experts (Ohanian 1990). SMLs, to a certain extent, are also viewed as celebrities because they have a substantial number of

followers on their social media accounts, which can be employed to endorse products. A study by Chetioui, Benlafqih, and Lebdaoui (2020) found that the perceived expertise of SMIs positively affects consumers' attitudes towards the SMI. Additionally, the perceived expertise of SMIs can build favorable attitudes towards a brand (Nafees et al. 2021). Likewise, SMIs who are viewed as experts in their areas can positively influence consumers' attitudes towards endorsed brands (Dhun, Dangi, and 2023; Trivedi and Sama 2020). Thus, it is hypothesised that:

H5: Expertise has a positive influence on attitudes.

2.4.6. Trustworthiness

Trustworthiness is defined by how honest, dependable, and reliable the source is perceived to be (Ohanian 1990). The likelihood of consumers trusting recommendations by SMIs is higher when the SMIs are deemed trustworthy (Koay et al. 2022). Consumers' trust in a product or service is found to be positively associated with the trust they place in the SMI endorsing it (Cooley and Parks-Yancy 2019). Chetioui, Benlafqih, and Lebdaoui (2020) reported that SMIs who are more trusted are more effective in influencing consumer choice, implying that highly trusted SMIs play a significant role in shaping consumers' attitudes and purchase decisions. Likewise, another study by Tiwari et al. (2024) found that SMIs who are perceived as trustworthy significantly impact consumer attitudes. Additionally, perceived trustworthiness is found to positively impact consumers' attitudes towards a brand (Nafees et al. 2021). Therefore, it is hypothesised that:

H6: Trustworthiness has a positive influence on attitudes.

2.4.7. Information quality

Information quality plays a critical role in ensuring effective communication by showcasing relevant and valuable information to the intended audience. Information quality refers to how well a brand can provide its target audience with relevant information about its products through marketing channels to support the consumer decision-making process (Hanaysha 2022). Information quality is an essential content-driven aspect of advertising that significantly influences consumers' attitudes towards social media advertisements (Taylor, Lewin, and Strutton 2011). For instance, perceived informativeness is found to positively influence an individual's attitudes towards a website (Kang and Kim 2006). When SMIs attempt to promote products or brands, it is important that they provide sufficient information regarding the endorsements for their followers. Herrando and Martín-de Hoyos (2022) showed that when SMIs' posts are perceived to be informative and entertaining by users, they are seen as having greater advertising value, which in turn fosters more positive attitudes towards the posts and subsequently improves purchase intentions. Thus, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H7: Information quality has a positive influence on attitudes.

2.4.8. Creativity

An image-based platform such as Instagram encourages creativity and motivates users to follow other users, brands, and influencers (Casaló, Flavián, and Ibáñez-Sánchez 2020).

Creative advertisements encourage individuals to form favourable attitudes towards the advertisements and later towards the brand (Reinartz and Saffert 2013). Likewise, social media users are more likely to develop favourable attitudes towards social media ads that are viewed as creative, leading to the formation of purchase intentions (J. Lee and Hong 2016). Furthermore, a study by Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. (2022a) suggested that the perceived creativity of an Instagram post can elicit positive emotions. Similarly, Casalo, Flavián, and Ibáñez-Sánchez (2021) demonstrated that the perceived creativity of Instagram advertisements and posts positively impacts positive emotions. Hence, the hypothesis below is formulated:

H8: Creativity has a positive influence on attitudes.

2.4.9. Design quality

SMLs frequently create and share user-generated content (UGC) as part of their content strategy. Sponsored UGC involves brands paying SMLs to endorse and promote their products on social media platforms (Wang 2021). UGC design quality refers to the overall appearance of the content as presented to users (Smith, Fischer, and Yongjian 2012). This quality reflects the level of coordination, harmonisation, and synchronisation among elements such as text, sound, audio, and video motions (Mohammad et al. 2020). Components like color scheme, graphics, layout, and design of an online interface can evoke positive attitudes from users. Nowadays, many social media platforms allow SMLs to curate interesting and captivating posts with different features to entice followers' attraction. Hence, it is suggested that consumers are more likely to develop positive attitudes towards products endorsed by SMLs when the sponsored posts are designed. Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

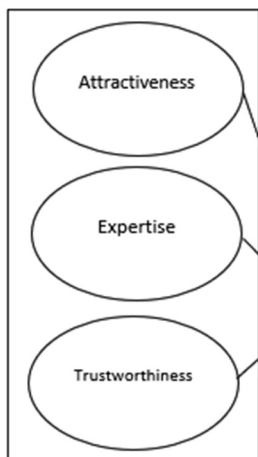
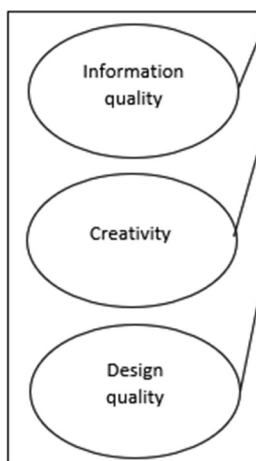
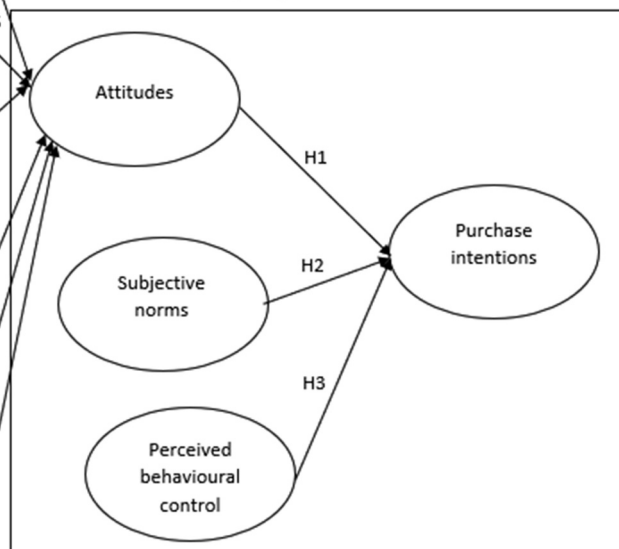
H9: Design quality has a positive influence on attitudes.

The full research model can be seen in [Figure 1](#).

3. Methodology

3.1. Population and sample

The data collection method for this study involves self-administered online questionnaires distributed to respondents that meet the criteria of, having an Instagram account and 2) following at least one SML on Instagram. Instagram was selected as the primary platform for the context of this research because nearly 80% of brands involved in influencer marketing use Instagram, and Instagram has the highest engagement rate compared to other social media platforms, such as Facebook (Influencer Marketing Hub 2024). The survey was created using Google Forms which includes a combination of filter questions and demographic questions to ensure respondents meet the criteria of the research scope and questions specific to the study's variables in question. Respondents were asked to identify one SML they are following on Instagram and to keep the SML in mind while answering the survey to ensure more accurate responses hence data of better quality. The survey link was shared across various social media platforms such as Facebook, WhatsApp,

SMIs' personal characteristics**SMIs' content characteristics****Theory of planned behaviour****Figure 1.** Research model.

and Instagram. Potential respondents were informed about the purpose of the study before their participation and subsequently, their consent was obtained. Prior to data collection, we conducted a power analysis to check the minimum sample size. G*Power suggested this study would need at least 98 participants (Faul et al. 2009). A total of 217 data was collected over an estimated period of 4 weeks and stored to maintain confidentiality.

Out of the 217 respondents, 172 (79.3%) were female, and 45 (20.7%) were male. The majority of respondents were between the ages of 19 and 24 (76%), followed by those aged 25 to 29 (17.5%). Respondents aged 30 to 34 made up 3.7%, those aged 35 to 39 comprised 0.9%, and 1.9% were aged between 40 and 45. Regarding ethnicity, the largest group was Chinese, making up 84.3% of the respondents, followed by Malay (11.1%), Indian (3.2%), and other races (1.4%). In terms of income levels, 77.4% of respondents fell

into the RM 0 - RM 2000 category, 15.2% were in the RM 2001 - RM 5000 range, 4.1% were in the RM 5001 - RM 8000 bracket, and 3.2% had incomes above RM 8000.

3.2. Measures

The measurement items were adapted from several past studies. The measurements of attractiveness, expertise, and trustworthiness are each assessed using five items adopted from Koay et al. (2022). The measurements of information quality (three items), creativity (four items), and design quality (four items) are adopted from Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. (2022a). Next, measurements of attitudes (four items), subjective norms (three items), and perceived behavioural control (four items) were adapted from Fishbein and Ajzen (2009). The construct of purchase intention is measured using three items adopted from Koay et al. (2023). A seven-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree) is utilised to measure all items.

4. Data analysis

The hypotheses mentioned above were evaluated using partial least squares structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM). PLS-SEM is a type of multivariate analysis within the structural equation modelling family, which also includes covariance-based structural equation modelling (CB-SEM) (Guenther et al. 2023; Lim and Koay 2024). PLS-SEM offers two main benefits: it allows for the inclusion of abstract (latent) variables in the model and it can estimate multiple dependence relationships. PLS-SEM was chosen over CB-SEM because it has fewer assumptions regarding normality, independence of observations, sample size, and it avoids identification issues. Additionally, given that this study aims to explore a complex model integrating various theoretical frameworks in an exploratory manner, PLS-SEM is more suitable than CB-SEM.

4.1. Common method bias

To check for common method bias, we employed Harman's one-factor test as described by Podsakoff et al. (2003). We conducted an unrotated exploratory factor analysis with all the items from the variables under study to see if a single factor accounted for the majority of the variance, which it did not. Additionally, we performed a full collinearity test, and all variance inflation factors were below 3.3 (Kock 2015), indicating no evidence of common method bias.

4.2. Measurement model

The initial step involves assessing the reflective model by examining the reliability and convergent validity of the items for each latent factor (Guenther et al. 2023). To evaluate the internal consistency of the model, the factor loadings for each item, Cronbach's alpha for each factor, composite reliability, and average variance extracted were analysed. Items with factor loadings below 0.7 are generally recommended for removal. However, items with factor loadings between 0.4 and 0.7 can be retained if

Table 1. Measurement model.

Construct	Item	Loading	Cronbach's alpha	Composite reliability	Average variance extracted
Attractiveness	ATT1: The [Social Media Influencer] is attractive.	0.788	0.842	0.886	0.614
	ATT2: The [Social Media Influencer] is classy.	0.862			
	ATT3: The [Social Media Influencer] is beautiful.	0.832			
	ATT4: The [Social Media Influencer] is elegant.	0.845			
	ATT5: The [Social Media Influencer] is sexy.	0.547			
Attitudes	ATTD1: I think that purchasing products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer] is good.	0.913	0.923	0.945	0.812
	ATTD2: I think that purchasing products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer] is pleasant.	0.924			
	ATTD3: I think that purchasing products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer] is beneficial.	0.898			
	ATTD4: I think that purchasing products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer] is interesting.	0.868			
Creativity	CRE1: The content shared by [Social Media Influencer] is unique.	0.880	0.889	0.923	0.750
	CRE2: The content shared by [Social Media Influencer] is really out of ordinary.	0.883			
	CRE3: The content shared by [Social Media Influencer] is intriguing.	0.855			
	CRE4: The content shared by [Social Media Influencer] is surprising.	0.847			
Design quality	DSQ1: The design of the posts shared by [Social Media Influencer] is well organised.	0.782	0.851	0.900	0.692
	DSQ2: The content of the posts shared by [Social Media Influencer], such as texts, graphics, and sounds, are well unified in the structure.	0.859			
	DSQ3: The content of videos, graphics and audios is appropriately assembled in the structure of the posts shared by [Social Media Influencer].	0.867			
	DSQ4: Components of the posts shared by [Social Media Influencer] are well harmonised.	0.816			
Expertise	EXP1: The [Social Media Influencer] is an expert.	0.882	0.918	0.939	0.754
	EXP2: The [Social Media Influencer] is experienced.	0.878			
	EXP3: The [Social Media Influencer] is knowledgeable.	0.861			
	EXP4: The [Social Media Influencer] is qualified.	0.894			
	EXP5: The [Social Media Influencer] is skilled.	0.823			
Information quality	INF1: The content in the posts of [Social Media Influencer] is easy to understand.	0.798	0.736	0.848	0.653
	INF2: The content in the posts of [Social Media Influencer] is new.	0.725			
	INF3: The content in the posts of [Social Media Influencer] is relevant for users.	0.891			
Perceived behavioural control	PBC1: I am confident that I can purchase products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer].	0.776	0.801	0.868	0.622
	PBC2: Purchasing products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer] is completely up to me.	0.790			
	PBC3: If I really wanted to, I could purchase products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer].	0.873			
	PBC4: For me to purchase products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer] is under my control.	0.707			

(Continued)

Table 1. (Continued).

Construct	Item	Loading	Cronbach's alpha	Composite reliability	Average variance extracted
Purchase intentions	PI1: In the future, I am likely to try one of the same services that [Social Media Influencer] endorsed or posted on social media.	0.911	0.912	0.944	0.850
	PI2: In the future, I am likely to try one of the same products that [Social Media Influencer] endorsed or posted on social media.	0.933			
	PI3: In the future, I am likely to try one of the same brands that [Social Media Influencer] endorsed or posted on social media.	0.921			
Subjective norms	SN1: Most people who are important to me think that I should purchase products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer].	0.920	0.932	0.957	0.880
	SN2: Most people whose opinions I value would approve of me making a purchase promoted by the [Social Media Influencer].	0.957			
	SN3: People around me approve of my purchasing products promoted by the [Social Media Influencer].	0.937			
Trustworthiness	TRW1: The [Social Media Influencer] is dependable.	0.798	0.921	0.941	0.762
	TRW2: The [Social Media Influencer] is honest.	0.880			
	TRW3: The [Social Media Influencer] is reliable.	0.909			
	TRW4: The [Social Media Influencer] is sincere.	0.875			
	TRW5: The [Social Media Influencer] is trustworthy.	0.897			

Table 2. HTMT criterion.

Construct	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
(1) (1) Attitudes										
(1) (2) Attractiveness	0.272									
(1) (3) Creativity	0.624	0.289								
(1) (4) Design quality	0.633	0.508	0.669							
(1) (5) Expertise	0.572	0.422	0.583	0.589						
(1) (6) Information quality	0.611	0.438	0.739	0.818	0.647					
(1) (7) Perceived behavioural control	0.533	0.464	0.291	0.428	0.462	0.372				
(1) (8) Purchase intentions	0.647	0.397	0.420	0.578	0.572	0.515	0.536			
(1) (9) Subjective norms	0.791	0.286	0.481	0.486	0.416	0.358	0.547	0.620		
(1) (10) Trustworthiness	0.676	0.366	0.677	0.658	0.697	0.714	0.513	0.574	0.484	

the construct's average variance extracted exceeds 0.5. As shown in [Table 1](#), all required criteria were met in the study, indicating no issues with reliability and convergent validity. The next step involves examining discriminant validity, which measures how distinct a construct is from other constructs. This will be assessed using the heterotrait-monotrait ratio (HTMT) because it offers better specificity and sensitivity compared to other discriminant validity criteria (Henseler, Ringle, and Sarstedt 2015). As shown in [Table 2](#), the HTMT criterion was satisfied for our PLS model, with none of the values exceeding 0.9.

Table 3. Structural model.

Relationship	Path coefficient	STD	t value	5.0%	95.0%	p value	Remark
H1: Attitudes -> Purchase intentions	0.331	0.111	2.994	0.152	0.516	.001	Supported
H2: Subjective norms -> Purchase intentions	0.229	0.091	2.527	0.086	0.385	.006	Supported
H3: Perceived behavioural control -> Purchase intentions	0.203	0.086	2.370	0.065	0.343	.009	Supported
H4: Attractiveness -> Attitudes	-0.060	0.056	1.080	-0.158	0.024	.140	Not supported
H5: Expertise -> Attitudes	0.136	0.098	1.387	-0.022	0.302	.083	Not supported
H6: Trustworthiness -> Attitudes	0.302	0.083	3.662	0.173	0.445	.000	Supported
H7: Information quality-> Attitudes	0.027	0.078	0.347	-0.099	0.157	.364	Not supported
H8: Creativity -> Attitudes	0.183	0.072	2.537	0.061	0.295	.006	Supported
H9: Design quality -> Attitudes	0.218	0.079	2.762	0.090	0.347	.003	Supported

Table 4. PLS_predict.

Item	Q ² predict	PLS		LM		PLS-LM		Predictive power
		RMSE	MAE	RMSE	MAE	RMSE	MAE	
PI1	0.336	1.075	0.784	1.127	0.826	-0.052	-0.042	Strong
PI2	0.356	0.996	0.759	1.076	0.811	-0.079	-0.053	
PI3	0.326	1.094	0.819	1.219	0.903	-0.126	-0.084	

4.3. Structural model

According to the structural model results as shown in Table 3, attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control have a significant positive influence on purchase intentions. Thus, H1, H2, and H3 were supported. In addition, only trustworthiness, creativity, and design quality have a significant positive influence on attitudes, but attractiveness, expertise, and information quality do not. Hence, H6, H8, and H9 were supported, but H4, H5, and H7 were not supported. Table 4 shows the results of PLS_predict. Given that all RMSE and MAE of the PLS model are smaller than that of the linear regression model (Shmueli et al. 2019), we can conclude that the research model has strong predictive relevance.

5. Findings

5.1. Theoretical implications

This study found that all three TPB variables including attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control are significant determinants of purchase intentions. Such findings indicate that consumers' positive evaluations of the products endorsed by SMIs play a crucial role in their purchase intentions (Tiwari et al. 2024). If consumers believe that the products are of high quality and beneficial, they are more likely to act on the SMIs' recommendations. Furthermore, social acceptance is another critical factor. For consumers to feel comfortable purchasing products recommended by SMIs, these actions must be seen as acceptable and even desirable within their social networks (Tiwari et al. 2024). This social validation can come from peers, family, or wider societal norms, reinforcing the consumers' decision to purchase. Lastly, perceived behavioural control was found to have

a significant positive influence on purchase intentions, suggesting that consumers need to feel that they can easily purchase the endorsed products (Peña-García et al. 2020). This includes having enough information about the purchasing process and ensuring that the products are within an affordable price range. SMIs should therefore make the buying process as straightforward as possible, providing clear instructions and ensuring that the products are reasonably priced for their target audience.

This study found that attractiveness does not influence consumer attitudes. One possible reason is that while SMIs may appear attractive, many might endorse products that are neither useful nor affordable, driven by the allure of hefty endorsement fees (Koay et al. 2023). As a result, consumers today may be more skeptical of products endorsed by SMIs. In addition, a study by Masuda et al. (2022) suggests that in order to entice consumers to purchase products from SMIs, SMIs' physical and social attractiveness must first develop parasocial relationships. Hence, parasocial relationships could be the key to bridging the relationship between attractiveness and attitudes. Additionally, expertise was not identified as a significant factor affecting attitudes, which is not consistent with past studies (e.g., Nafees et al. 2021). This could be because this study focuses on Instagram, whose unique interactive design may impact how SMI expertise is perceived differently compared to other social networks like TikTok or LinkedIn (J. Han and Balabanis 2024). Furthermore, users might be skeptical about SMI endorsements, especially if the content seems inauthentic or overly commercialized (Koay, Teoh, and Soh 2021). However, trustworthiness was found to have a significant effect on attitudes, consistent with past studies (Nafees et al. 2021, Tiwari et al. 2024). Consumers develop positive attitudes towards a brand when it is associated with an SMI perceived as trustworthy, as they are more likely to transfer their trust in the SMI to the brand (Cooley and Parks-Yancy 2019).

In addition, regarding content characteristics, our research indicates that the quality of information provided by SMIs does not significantly influence attitudes. However, creativity and design quality have been shown to have a significant positive impact on attitudes. This finding aligns with the observation that consumers nowadays are generally less focused on the factual accuracy or depth of information shared by SMIs when bombarded with tons of information on social media (Geng, Chen, and Wang 2024). Instead, they are more attracted to visually appealing and innovative posts. The emphasis on creativity and design resonates with consumers, as previous studies have demonstrated that creative content tends to evoke positive emotions (Casaló, Flavián, and Ibáñez-Sánchez 2021; Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. 2022a). These positive emotions, in turn, may foster favorable consumer responses, such as increased engagement, brand loyalty, and purchase intentions.

5.2. Managerial implications

Based on the findings, we offer several important managerial implications. SMIs have the power to shape social norms within their communities, making products seem more desirable and accepted (Tiwari et al. 2024). SMIs who create a sense of social proof can drive higher purchase intentions. Additionally, SMIs can engage their followers in creating content related to the brand, amplifying the perception of social endorsement and community support. To increase consumers' perceived behavioural control, brands and

SMLs should simplify the purchasing process by providing clear calls to action and easy access to product links within influencer content. This ensures that the path from endorsement to purchase is as seamless as possible. Furthermore, it is crucial for brands to equip SMLs with detailed product information to share with their audience. When consumers feel well-informed and confident in their purchase decisions, their perceived behavioural control increases (Tiwari et al. 2024).

Our study found that attitudes towards products endorsed by SMLs positively influence consumers' purchase intentions and attitudes are essentially influenced by trustworthiness, creativity, and design quality. Hence, we recommend that brands prioritise collaborating with SMLs who are perceived as trustworthy by their audience (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. 2022a). Trustworthiness can be assessed through factors such as authenticity, transparency, and a history of honest endorsements. Brand managers should conduct thorough background checks and evaluate SML's engagement with their followers to ensure they maintain a credible reputation. On the other hand, SMLs can develop their trustworthiness by providing sincere and honest endorsements. They should only promote products or services that reflect their values and beliefs, rather than doing so purely for monetary gain. Additionally, being transparent about sponsored content and brand partnerships is essential. Just as Rome wasn't built in a day, building trust takes time and requires consistent effort.

Furthermore, brands should foster creative collaborations by encouraging SMLs to create content that aligns with the brand's values while showcasing their unique creative style. Brands can provide guidelines but should allow SMLs the freedom to express their creativity. This approach ensures the content is engaging and resonates well with the audience, thereby enhancing the effectiveness of the endorsement. For instance, SMLs should use the latest features offered by Instagram such as inserting trendy music, posting innovative reels, and using interesting hashtags. Additionally, brands should select SMLs who invest in creating high-quality posts. The visual appeal and overall design quality of an SML's content are crucial. Brands should provide SMLs with high-quality images, videos, and other resources to ensure the final content is visually compelling (Cheung, Leung, Aw, et al. 2022a). Offering training or tools for content creation can also help SMLs produce higher-quality posts that better attract and retain consumer attention.

6. Conclusion

This study proposes and empirically tests an extended TPB model to understand consumers' purchase intentions for products endorsed by SMLs. The extended model incorporates factors related to SMLs' personal and content characteristics to predict attitudes toward endorsed products, enhancing the original model's utility in the SML context. The findings of this study can be helpful for marketers and brand managers in selecting the most suitable SMLs as brand ambassadors. In particular, finding SMLs who are trustworthy and can create creative and well-designed content is essential for developing consumers' positive attitudes toward products endorsed by SMLs. However, this study has several limitations. Firstly, it was conducted without focusing on a specific product or service category, which may affect the results. Future research

could provide deeper insights by investigating consumer attitudes and purchase intentions within specific products, services, or industry contexts. Additionally, the findings may not be directly applicable to SMIs from all types of social media on platforms other than Instagram, which was the focus of this study. Future studies could apply this model to other SMI-related platforms such as TikTok, X (formerly known as Twitter), Facebook, and other prominent social media platforms to increase generalisability. Furthermore, this study may not be representative of the general consumer group, as all respondents were from Malaysia. Findings may differ in other geographic areas due to varying cultural and social contexts. This study also did not account for differences among nano, micro, macro, and mega influencers. Future research is recommended to reassess the model, considering these different classification groups based on follower count, to refine the model and its applicability.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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